

Struggle for Democracy PPP Era (2008–2013)

This lecture includes

PPP in Parliament

Restoration of Supreme Court Judges

Judicial Activism during PPP

Government

18th Amendment & Initiation of CPEC

Removal of Yusuf Raza Gilani

CLO 02 & 03

Analyze Pakistan's political and constitutional evolution from 1958 to the present, including civil-military relations, democratic transitions, and governance challenges. Also, able to critically evaluate governance reforms, constitutional amendments, economic initiatives (e.g., CPEC), and their impact on political stability and national development

Political Context (2008)

- End of Musharraf Era
- 2008 Elections – PPP Government
- War on Terror & Economic Crisis
- First Civilian Government Completing Tenure

The Elections 2008 were held in the turbulent security environment and under the pseudo-democratic regime of General Musharraf which mainly aimed to backlash the democratization process in Pakistan. Pakistan People's Party Parliamentary (PPPP), the electoral wing of the PPP won the majority seats (95 out of 248 in the National Assembly) and formed the government in collaboration with the Mutahidda Qaumi Movement (MQM), Awami National Party (ANP), Jama'iat Ulama-e-Islam (JUI) and PML (N). Later, the PML (N) left the coalition and sat on the opposition benches. The PPP regime completed its constitutional tenure of five years in 2013 but could not be re-elected.

18th Amendment Background

After the elections, the arch rivals in the history and opponents at NRO e.g. the PPP and PML (N) joined to form the coalition government which then was interpreted as a positive sign for the sustenance of democracy in Pakistan.

- Charter of Democracy (2006)
- Restoration of Parliamentary Supremacy
- Removal of Presidential Powers

Key Features of 18th Amendment

- Removal of Article 58(2)(b)
- Strengthened Prime Minister
- Provincial Autonomy
- Judicial Commission for Appointments

Despite of its failure to practice the good governance, the PPP regime steered a number of structural changes in the overall politico-constitutional structure of state.

Provincial Autonomy

The major notable successes of the aforesaid Zardari regime included the restructuring the NFC award, securing provincial autonomy and re-activation of the Council of Common Interests

i.e. through successfully passing the 18th Constitutional Amendment

- Abolished Concurrent List
- Education, Health, Culture to Provinces
- Strengthened Federalism

Significance & Criticism

- Democratic Restoration
- Stronger Parliament
- Implementation Challenges
- Fiscal Concerns

The first challenge for the PPP regime was to face widespread and regular public protests for the restoration of judiciary.

The restoration of judiciary proved a bad omen for the PPP regime because it resulted the restoration of the paused judicial activism CJ Iftikhar Chaudhary.

Removal of Yusuf Raza Gilani

- The legal battle ended in June 2012, when the SC removed the then Prime Minister Yousaf Raza Gilani from his office on the charges of contempt.
- The deadlock was finally ended in October 2012 when the government complied with the orders of SC to contact with the Swiss authorities and sought concession regarding the early demanded immunity for the office of president

Raja Pervaiz Ashraf as PM

- After the removal of Yousaf Raza Gilani, the PPP appointed Raja Pervaiz Ashraf as the next Prime Minister.
- The PPP faced another setback from judiciary in December, 2012, when the court issued an arrest warrant against its second prime minister Raja Pervaiz Ashraf on the charges of corruptions during his early held portfolio of the ministry of water and power.

Economic Issues faced

In 2008, the PPP regime inherited a war torn economy which was mostly dependent on foreign aid and the financial assistance of the IMF. Further, the PPP regime had been plagued by the corruption charges throughout its tenure and thus had less focus upon the economic issues of the state

End of PPP era-2013

The leadership of PPP regime, especially ex-president Asif Zardari has been one of the key targets for media. President Zardari, prime ministers Yousaf Raza Gilani and Raja Pervaiz Ashraf and other leadership of the PPP regime faced corruption charges and were in a constant tussle with judiciary.

Crippling power and gas shortages, unbridled price hike, burden of foreign loans, economic collapse, the weakened state institutions like PIA, Pakistan Railways, Pakistan Steel, WAPDA and false claims that the country is making progress were some of the 'gifts' of the PPP regime which the public could not neglect in the next elections to be held in 2013.

PPP regime had the chance to focus on the popular issues of literacy, public health, economic stability, and terrorism, but she failed to use her opportunity during its constitutional tenure e.g. (2008-13) effectively. So, there were hardly any "achievements" which the PPP regime could have en-cashed to win the next elections to be held in 2013.